shi Vikas Yojana (PKVY), the National Project on Organic Farming, the Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana and the Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture. Since last year, MOVCDNER outlays have increased to Rs 200 crore, from Rs 134 crore in its inception. From 2016 to 2021, some 74,880 ha. has become chemical-free in the eight northeastern states, and the Centre is targeting the conversion of another 0.1 mha by the end of 2024.

PKVY funds have so far helped clear 0.4 mha for organic farming in nine states; state-specific programmes in Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh added nearly 1 mha to that. Other states, too, are taking steps. Chhattisgarh has launched the Godhan Nyay Scheme, where it buys cattle dung at Rs 2/ kg and provides farmers with vermicompost for Rs 8/ kg. Odisha has come out with its own organic policy, which envisions 30 model organic clusters in five districts. Seven districts are already in the game via integrated nutrient management and climate-resilient irrigation projects—the state has already linked millets produced via natural farming by tribals to its PDS (public distribution system). State nutrition programmes, ICDS (Integrated Child Development Services), mid-day meals...it touches all of that.

THE OTHER PITFALLS

Meanwhile, agriculture ministry officials are working on a plan to create one cluster of natural farming in each block in the country. They believe it may work as almost 52 per cent of agriculture takes place in rain-fed areas where the reliance on chemical fertilisers is already relatively lower,. Fertilisers, chemical or organic, are key to the debate since they add to input costs. Most organic farmers crib that they cannot command the differential pricing that can justify making the switch from chemical to organic fertilisers. "If we go to local markets, we don't get anything extra. We have to look for private buyers or corporate houses," says Suresh Desai, who runs an organic farmers' club at Bedkihal, in Karnataka's Belgaum district.

There are other pitfalls, too, on the organic farmer's freeway. Since September 2017, no one is allowed to manufacture, pack, sell, offer for sale, market or distribute or import any organic food unless they follow the Food Safety and Standards (Organic Foods) Regulation. Several organic farmers INDIA TODAY spoke to said they don't trust their state governments' certification processes. Several farmers, they allege, blend organic with chemical farming but manage to clear traces of synthetic chemicals before inspection. The government is trying to convince farmers to undergo these certifications—it funds the initial certification, but expects the farmer to bear the high cost of renewal. "Several farmers have dropped out after the initial period," says Rajdeo V., an organic farmer from Karnataka's Belavadi region. The state was among the first to usher in an organic farming policy, aiming to convert at least 10 per cent of its cultivable area by 2022. But at 0.2 mha, it has covered a mere 1.2 per cent of its net sown area. Desai, who is helping farmers in Karnataka, Punjab, Haryana, Telangana and Maharashtra to grow organic sugarcane, says the mandatory certification is discriminatory. "Producers of chemical-laced food products are allowed to come to the market without any certification. And farmers who are determined to go eco-friendly have to undergo this."

If India is to plough these fields in a more determined manner, the solutions must also answer the needs of the farmers—naturally. Many countries refuse Indian exports citing heavy chemical residue. Scoring better on the exports front, reducing the heavy subsidy burden that fertilisers entail, improving farm earnings, and doing all that while revitalising the soil and offering an overall ecologically sustainable model—these are the challenges organic/ natural farming has to surmount. ■



AGENT OF CHANGE
Umendra Dutt of the Krishi Virasat Mission at his farm in Punjab

THE STUMBLING BLOCKS

- The farmland needs to be left idle for three years to leach out chemicals from the soil
- Too expensive and complicated for small/ marginal farmers to make the switch
- The marketing network for the produce is still very limited
- Farmers are unable to claim differential prices for their organic and natural farm produce in local markets
- More corporates need to be encouraged to invest in organic; many have been discouraged by the recent repeal of farm laws
- The certification system for organic farming is still not efficient